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Week in Review: May 27-June 3

Jeff Cunningham

Good evening, and welcome to Week in Review.

Let's see what's in the news today.

Alex Shvartsman: to Russia with Love

You may have noticed that I do not have a Russian accent... that's correct, I am not Alex Shvartsman, nor do I speak Russian. Swamped with winning Grand Prix and managing his new store, King's Games, Alex is taking some much-needed time off from the Week in Review team. Until he returns, I will be taking over as the new king of late nite. What to expect: weekly updates (every Wednesday), additional interviews and sections, and more of the in-depth event coverage you've come to know.

Alex will be remembered for his reporting contributions to the game of **Magic: the Gathering**, and for his love of fine wines. I hope to extend his legacy of excellence. Thanks Alex!



Grand Prix-Pittsburgh



Like most Grand Prix on the East Coast, Pittsburgh drew in large crowds: one hundred and ninety five teams showed up for the tournament. This led to eight rounds of Swiss, and a 6-2 minimum cutoff for Day 2. Most North American pro teams were in attendance, including 2020 (Dave Rood, Elijah Pollock, Steve Wolfman) fresh off a Masters Finals, The Jokas (Kyle Rose, Norman Woods, Eric James), last year's defending champions hoping to prove that

Pro Tour-London wasn't a fluke, and Illuminati (Zvi Mowshowitz, Alex Shvartsman, Justin Gary), consistently strong finishers in the team format. Notable absentees were Bob Maher, Dave Williams, and Neil Reeves (Bob'n for Apples), Gary Talim, Brian Davis, and Phil Freneau (Nut Low Alliance), and Kenny Hsiung, Geddes Cooper, and Jason Opalka (FatHers).

I myself made the trip to Pittsburgh in order to replace Gary Wise, who was quarantined for SARS, on Eugene Harvey and Mike Turian's team. I stayed in their house, a veritable gamer's mansion, that's only flaw was a shower that begged the question "is there something I should know?" Mike, Eugene and I began the tournament 4-0, but only went 1-2-1 with our last decks, missing the cut. Even so, the tournament was valuable practice for Pro Tour-Boston, which shares the format. After the dust settled on Day 1, Prodigy, a team of Florida locals lead by Limited specialist Charlie Gindy, topped the standings with the Super-Rad Supernova close behind. Rounding out the rest of the top twenty were mostly mainstays (Ubermenschen, Illuminati, Slay Pillage Gerard,) but there were a few surprises. E.G.L (Pete Radjonc, Jeff Fung, Terry Tsang,) a team of Canadians heralding from the silver age of the Pro Tour, The Fun Police (Tim Aten, Mike Aten, John Hunka,) a team notable for the inclusion of Star City writer Tim Aten, and former U.S. Nationals runner-up John Hunka, and Northern Lights #5 (Mike Long, Mike Kryzwicki, Justin Schneider,) a team of infamous names. Day 2 was only three rounds of draft, causing some frustration among pro players who felt that the more skill intensive of the two formats played on the weekend had the smallest effect on a team's final standing. The Top 4 of the tournament contained Illuminati, who squeaked in, Prodigy, who managed to get the win and a draw they needed after their 8-0 Day 1 performance, Northern Lights #5, who beat out Ubermenschen in an exceptionally close match, and Phoque Foundation, a team of up and coming French Canadians. In a surprise upset, Northern Lights #5 would lose to Prodigy despite exquisite mind games by Mike Long. Illuminati beat Phoque Foundation in another tight match. The finals were a blowout; as soon as Alex Shvartsman, considered the underdog in his matchup, quickly took both games, his team rushed to victory. Congratulations to Illuminati, clearly one of the top teams to watch at Pro Tour-Boston. Consensus for best named teams went to Brock Bottom, Zangeif Dhahisiem and Eardle, and I Blame Bung. I had a chance to get the inside scoop on the team names. Brock Bottom is the physical embodiment of Brock Parker's personal voyage to rock Bottom. Zangeif, Dhahisiem and Eardle is a Street Fight reference, because the team members thought Street Fighter was cool, but didn't actually know how to spell the character's names. Bung, Team I Blame Bung's namesake. According to my source, "goes by the name Bango, Bungo, BKC, Bung, but actually named Byung. He's a mathematical genius who wants to be a chef. Once got trapped inside a couch." Oh Bung!

German Nationals

With last year's German Team victory at Worlds still fresh in everyone's minds, everyone's wondering if they will be able to repeat last year's performance. Their team's going to have to kick Budde... so to speak! This weekend's Nationals brought out 149 competitors, many of them regulars on the Pro Tour. Kai Budde, Dirk Baberowski, Christian Luhrs, Marco Blume, Jens Krause, Wolfgang Eder, Wenzel Krautman, Rene Kraft, Reinhard Blech, Mark Zieger, Patrick Mello, Darryl Snaggletooth, Jim Herold, Andre Muller, Janosch Kuhn, Peer Kroger, and Jan Brinkman were all in attendance.



While Kai Budde, playing Psychatog, narrowly missed the Top 8 due to an uncharacteristic play error, his teammate Dirk Baberowski, playing elves with red, made the cut. Once Top 8 play



began, Dirk continued to win, and took the title in a Top 8 containing a diverse collection of decks: two monoblack control, two Reanimator, goblins, g-u-w madness, and Psychatog.

The 2003 German National team is Dirk Baberowski, Thomas Neumaier, and Falk Bernhardt. Baberowski is obviously a top player, and Kai Budde had vouched for the other two relative unknowns' play skill. With only the Finnish national team coming close, the German team is currently the team to beat for Worlds.

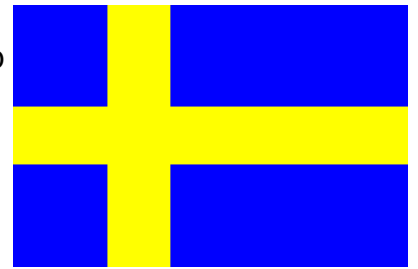
Here is Dirk's winning deck:

Main Deck		Sideboard
4 Wooded Foothills	1 Coat of Arms	4 Phantom Centaur
4 Karplusan Forest		1 Mountain
4 Wirewood Lodge	1 other spell	4 Flaring Pain
8 Forest		1 Caller of the Claw
		1 Coat of Arms
20 land		2 Naturalize
4 Birchlore Ranger		2 Goblin Sharpshooter
4 Llanowar Elves		
2 Taunting Elf		15 sideboard cards
4 Wirewood Hivemaster		
4 Wellwisher		
4 Timberwatch Elf		
4 Bloodline Shaman		
4 Wirewood Pride		
4 Seeker of Skybreak		
1 Caller of the Claw		
4 Wirewood Herald		
39 creatures		

Swedish Nationals

Sweden, home to gravy trainers Mattias Jorstedt, Anton Jonsson, Rickard Osterberg, Jimmy Oman, Johan Sadeghpour, Olle Rade, Kristian Hellman and Jens Thoren, has recently become a hotbed of Magic talent. This year's Nationals drew 146 competitors.

The Top 8 featured Kristian Hellman (playing Wake,) and Johan Sadeghpour (playing g-b Braids.) The Top 8 contained 4 Wake decks, 2 'Tog decks, 2 monoblack control decks, a u-g deck, and the b-g deck.



Bertil Elfgren defeated Johan Sadeghpour 2-1 to take the championship.

Sweden's National Team is Bertil Elfgren, Johan Sadeghpour, and Jonathan Bergstrom. If Sadeghpour's strong play rubs off on his teammates, they'll have a good shot at Worlds.

Here is Bertil Elfgren's winning deck:

Meet Tar Black		
Main Deck		Sideboard
3 Cabal Coffers	4 Chainer's Edict	3 Guiltfeeder
23 Swamp	4 Corrupt	3 Cabal Therapy
	3 Diabolic Tutor	1 Disrupting Scepter
26 land	4 Duress	1 Engineered Plague
	2 Haunting Echoes	1 Nantuko Shade
3 Nantuko Shade	1 Innocent Blood	1 Mind Sludge
2 Visara the Dreadful	1 Mind Sludge	1 Mutilate
2 Undead Gladiator	3 Mutilate	2 Persecute
	2 Skeletal Scrying	1 Riptide Replicator
7 creatures	3 Smother	1 Visara the Dreadful
	27 other spells	15 sideboard cards

Italian Nationals

Italian Nationals was this past weekend as well, but it's yet unknown who won and with what. Italians regulars on the Pro Tour are Dario Minieri, Raffaele Le Moro, and Andrea Santin. Kai Budde's next article will explore the results from this, and other recent national tournaments.

Gary Wise: SARS Free (for Now)

After visiting a hospital in Toronto's "SARS"borough area, pro player Gary Wise was informed that he would be forced to participate in a week-long quarantine, causing him to miss GP-Pittsburgh.

Finally, the quarantine has ended, and it's official - Gary is SARS free! "Let's just say, I'm happy I don't have SARS, and I enjoyed my



brief vacation from the rat race that is Pro Magic.” Thanks Gary, stay healthy!

Team Togit: Cursed?

Craig Krempals, 9th at Pro Tour: Yokohama. Patrick Sullivan, rated 76th at the time of the Top 75 rating invites for U.S. Nationals. Adam Horvath, 17th *Scourge* Prerelease (Top 16 got prize). And now, a 5th place at GP-Pittsburgh as a team, even after going undefeated on Day 2!

The current buzz on the PT airways: these suckers are the victims of black magic!

Oops! We Made a Mistake!

An update to my Chewing the Fat: *Scourge* Draft article posted a couple days ago. I would like to apologize. It was written before the Prerelease, and was originally intended for the *Sideboard Magazine*, not the rapidly updated internet community. Most of the information is valid, but I feel it necessary to mention that several of my perceptions have changed since GP-Pittsburgh. Here are my current Top 5 picks from each color in *Scourge*.

Red

1. Zombie Cutthroat
2. Torrent of Fire
3. Chartooth Cougar
4. Scattershot
5. Spark Spray

White

1. Zombie Cutthroat
2. Dragon Scales
3. Aven Farseer
4. Aven Liberator
5. Frontline Strategist

Black

1. Zombie Cutthroat
2. Lingering Death
3. Twisted Abomination
4. Clutch of Undeath
5. Carrion Feeder

Blue

1. Zombie Cutthroat
2. Rush of Knowledge
3. Frozen Solid
4. Raven Guild Initiate
5. Shoreline Raider

Green

1. Zombie Cutthroat
2. Wirewood Guardian



It's no mistake – this guy is great for any deck.

3. Fierce Empath
4. Krosan Drover
5. Accelerated Mutation

Play of the Week

Mind games still play an important part of **Magic**, and Mike Long has always been a pretty tricky fellow. His latest is a doozy, turning what would almost certainly be a loss for anyone else into a win.

Playing in the Top 4 of Grand Prix-Pittsburgh, it was Northern Lights #5's Mike Long pitted against Prodigy's Manny Orellana.



It was game 2, with Orellana already up thanks to a **Sparksmith** draw, and things were looking grim for Long. Both were at low life and had plenty of creatures committed to the board, including an **Flamewave Invoker** and eight lands for Orellana. Things were about to get even more grim when Orellana tapped seven lands to play a game-ending spell: **Form of the Dragon**. As the card was about an inch above getting dropped onto the table, Long stopped Orellana, "I'll probably have a response to that." Muttering to himself, presumably doing math, Long spoke aloud "No... no... that won't work... you can just Flamewave me for five, then for five again... hmmm." Eventually, he finished, "are you still going to cast that spell?" Orellana declined, preferring Mike's plan of double Flamewaving. Mike clued him in to the real situation at the end of the turn with a **Choking Tethers** to tap all of his blockers, and a salt-in-the-wound tonguelash "sucker".

Are you still going to cast that?

Do not trust your opponent for strategy advice, especially when your opponent is Mike freaking Long.

Mike Long, I award you Play of the Week!

Bad Play of the Week

Spencer Morrison was playing against Craig Krempals in a side draft at GP-Pittsburgh. As both players had slow green decks (Craig with a black splash, Spencer with blue,) the game reached a stalemate. Craig passed the turn, and Spencer flipped over a morph - **Proteus Machine** - and declared it a bird. He untapped, and calmly attacked it into Craig's 7/7 **Enormous Baloth**. Craig blocked. His opponent stopped him, "it's a bird". Craig informed him that that did not, in fact, give it flying, and after calling a judge, Spencer put his **Proteus**

Machine into the graveyard. Frustrated, he conceded the game on the spot, but not before showing Craig the worst part — the double Airborne Aid left useless in his hand!

Spencer Morrison, I award you Bad Play of the Week!

Magic Trivia

It's Type 1, you're on the first turn of the game. It's your upkeep step. How can you win the game before your main phase? NOTE: There are two solutions

Quote of the Week

*"I wish there was a **Magic** zoo so I could pet the Birchlores."* - Jackson Cunningham

Note the lack of flying



Next Week

- South Korean and Mexican National Tournaments
- Will the real CoolAeo please stand up?
- 16 **Magic** pros talk about their families

Hot news items and plays of the week can be sent to me at ffejontheirc@yahoo.com.



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